

How can we compare the performance of different agencies, providers or initiatives (benchmarking)?

It can be useful to compare the performance of similar initiatives against each other. This is called benchmarking. When you are benchmarking, it is important to make sure that you are comparing like-for-like.

One way of making sure that you are comparing like-for-like is to think in terms of benchmarking always being about comparing indicators from two or more organizations, agencies, providers, policies or initiative's DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams. This helps you to ensure that what the initiatives are trying to achieve is very similar because this will be reflected in the similarity of their respective DoView diagrams.

While benchmarking may involve comparing a full DoView strategy/outcomes diagram, it does not have to. It can compare indicators from subpages of such a diagram where these subpages are similar. For instance, a specific back-office function common to a number of different organizations can be compared even where the overall mission of the different organizations is not the same. The two organizations' strategy/outcomes diagrams may both have a similar subpage focused on a specific function.

Benchmarking is best done using controllable indicators (Component D in the DoView Planning Framework (D1)). This is because we know that if controllable indicators have been measured as having occurred, it is the organization, agency, provider, policy, or initiative rather than some other factor that has made them occur.

This is not the case with not-necessarily controllable indicators (outcomes), and the lack of ability to attribute improvements to an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative with these measures reduces their relevance as benchmarking measures. This is because you cannot be sure what has made them happen. This is unless impact evaluation has been undertaken with both of the initiatives that are being compared. In this case, this will have proved that the initiatives are what is making these higher-level indicators of outcomes improve. This When Benchmarking is Appropriate Checklist (F4) steps you through doing benchmarking with a DoView diagram.